Parliamentary, Presidential, and Semi-Presidential Democracies

Comparative Politics

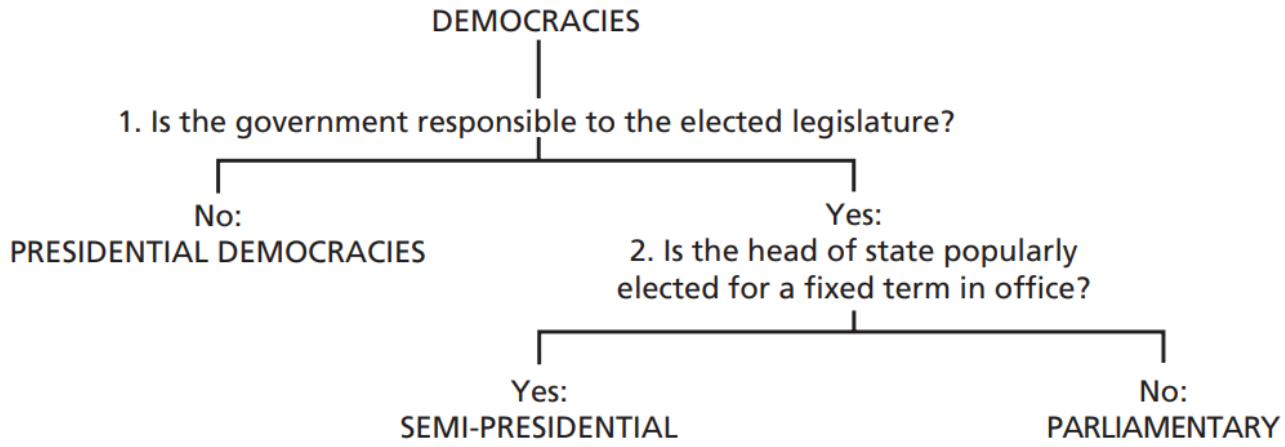
November 15-19, 2021

Last time

- Democracy is all about making decisions via majority rule
- We discussed problems of group decision making that come from this
- Yet governments in democracies manage to overcome these problems through institutions
- **This week:** Government formation

Types of democracy

FIGURE 12.1 **Classifying Parliamentary, Presidential, and Semi-Presidential Democracies**



- The formal title of the head of state does not matter
- **Legislative responsibility:** Legislative majority has constitutional power to remove a government from office *without cause*

Map 12.1 **Parliamentary, Presidential, and Semi-Presidential Democracies around the World in 2015**

Parliamentary democracies

- The **government** is composed by a **prime minister** and a **cabinet**
- **Prime minister:** Chief executive and head of government
- **Cabinet:** Ministers `(secretaries)` in charge of various departments
- The **executive branch** and the **government** are the same thing
- Government members are **elected legislators**

Legislative responsibility

- Legislature can vote to remove a government *without cause*
- **Vote of no confidence:** Legislature initiates, government resigns if fails to secure majority
- **Constructive vote of no confidence:** Must also propose a new government
- **Vote of confidence:** Government initiates, must resign if fails to obtain majority
- Rules specify restrictions to the frequency of these votes

Responsibility doctrines

- Different beliefs on who cabinet members respond to
- **Ministerial responsibility:** Cabinet ministers bear ultimate responsibility of what happens in their ministry
- **Collective cabinet responsibility:** Ministers publicly support collective cabinet decisions or must resign otherwise

Government formation in parliamentary democracies

- Voters **DO NOT** elect governments
- They elect legislators that negotiate over how to form a government
- Head of state presides over government formation
- Sometimes a mere formality `(e.g. British crown)`, sometimes they play a role `(e.g. Czech president)`
- They usually appoint an elected legislator to lead government formation:
  - **Formateur:** Designated to form the government, often becomes PM
  - **Informateur:** A more neutral figure, suggests politically feasible coalitions and nominates a formateur

Cabinet formation

- In practice, the formateur is usually the leader of the largest legislative party
- They must put together a cabinet that is acceptable to the legislative majority
- Most of the time, a single party does not have a majority, so they must bargain with other parties
- Usually, once formed, the new government must be confirmed by an **investiture vote**
- Government rules until:

  1. They are defeated in a vote of no confidence **OR**
  2. A new election is necessary

- If defeated, a **caretaker government** takes place `(sometimes the same government)` until a new government is formed
- Caretaker governments are not expected to lead major reforms

How to form a government?

Table 12.3 **West German Legislative Elections in 1987**

Party	Seats	Percentage
Christian Democrats (CDU/CSU)	223	44.9
Social Democrats (SPD)	186	37.4
Free Democrats (FDP)	46	9.3
Greens	42	8.5
Total	497	100

- No party received enough votes to have a legislative majority

Table 12.4 **Potential West German Governments in 1987**

Party	Seats	Percentage	Surplus seats
CDU/CSU + SPD + Greens + FDP	497	100	248
CDU/CSU + SPD + Greens	451	90.7	202
CDU/CSU + SPD + FDP	455	91.5	206
CDU/CSU + FDP + Greens	311	62.6	62
SPD + FDP + Greens	274	55.1	25
CDU/CSU + SPD	409	82.2	160
CDU/CSU + FDP	269	54.1	20
CDU/CSU + Greens	265	53.3	16
SPD + FDP	232	46.7	–17
SPD + Greens	228	45.9	–21
FDP + Greens	88	17.7	–161
SPD	186	37.4	–63
CDU/CSU	223	44.9	–26
Greens	42	8.5	–207
FDP	46	9.3	–203

Possible coalitions

Table 12.5 **Potential Majority West German Governments Containing the CSU/CDU in 1987**

Party	Seats	Percentage	Surplus seats
CDU/CSU + SPD + Greens + FDP	497	100	248
CDU/CSU + SPD + Greens	451	90.7	202
CDU/CSU + SPD + FDP	455	91.5	206
CDU/CSU + FDP + Greens	311	62.6	62
CDU/CSU + SPD	409	82.2	160
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- In return for their loyalty, the formateur offers cabinet positions
- Offer in proportion to party size in the legislature `(Gamson's law)`
- Ideally, you want a **minimal winning coalition (MWC):** No more parties than those required to keep a majority
- But, who to side with?

Assumptions

- Whether a coalition is feasible depends on what we assume about politicians' goals
- **Office-seeking politicians:** Want as much office as possible
- **Policy-seeking politicians:** Wants to shape policy
- In reality, a mixture of both, but it helps to analyze these separately

Office-seeking world

- You would want a MWC
- You also want the **least minimal winning coalition**
- **Least minimal winning coalition:** The MWC with the lowest number of surplus seats

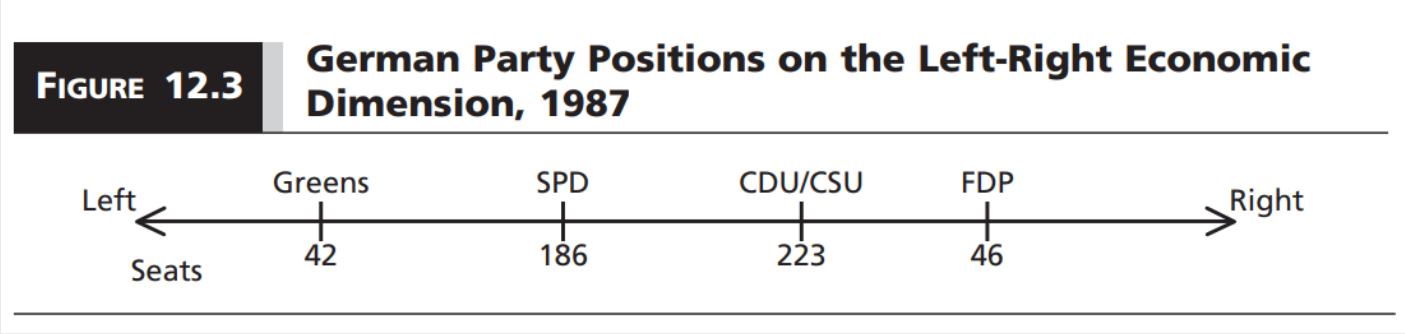
Office-seeking in the Germany example

- Three MWC:
    1. CDU/CSU + SPD (160 seats)
    2. CDU/CSU + FDP (20 surplus seats)
    3. **CDU/CSU + Greens (16 surplus seats)**

Policy-seeking world

- Formateur gets other parties to join by **making policy concessions**
- Larger parties will likely get larger policy concessions
- To minimize concessions, you want to form coalitions with parties close to you in the policy space
- You also want a **connected least minimal winning coalition**

Policy-seeking in the Germany example



- **CDU/CSU + Greens** is the smallest coalition, but not connected
- **CDU/CSU + SPD** is connected but not the smallest
- **CDU/CSU + FDP** is the **smallest connected coalition** `(This happened in real life)`
- **Bottomline:** Coalitions are a mix of office-seeking and policy-seeking considerations

Government types

- **Single-party majority:** One party with majority
- **Minimal winning coalition:** Many parties, just enough to get majority
- **Single-party minority government:** One party, no majority
- **Minority coalition government:** Many parties, no majority
- **Surplus majority government** Many parties, way above majority

Minority and surplus majority

- Why do we see anything beyond strict majorities?
- **Minority governments:**
  - Implicit majority without cabinent concessions `(perhaps emphasis in policy)`
  - Government changes coalitions on the fly depending on policy objectives `(similar to median voter theorem)`
- **Surplus majorities:**
  - Periods of crisis that require national unity
  - Government wants to implement major reforms that require supermajorities `(e.g. constituional reforms)`

Presidential democracies

- The government comprises the **president and the cabinet**
- President is **head of state** and **chief executive**
- **Ministers' only job** is to be in the cabinet
- Usually not elected officials, but appointed by president
- Sometimes not partisan, but "technical" appointments
- The **executive branch** and the **government** are the same thing

Government formation

- The government **cannot be dismissed** by legislative majority `(unless impeachment)`
- President is the **formateur** and their party is always in government

Minority government

- **Portfolio coalition $\neq$ Legislative coalition**
- Minority governments are more common
- Possible to have a minority government without implicit support of the legislative majority `(divided government)`
- **Office-seeking world:** No coalition government
- **Policy-seeking world:** Coalition depends on presidential legislative powers

Presidential legislative powers

- Presidents vary on the power they have to influence legislative decision making
- Powers include:
  - **Decree authority:** Pass laws in some domains without legislative approval
  - **Legislative initiative:** Some policy areas can only have bills introduced by the president
  - **Fast-tracking legislation:** Sets the legislative agenda
  - **Legislative veto:** Block a bill aproved by legislature
  - **Presidentially initiated referendums:** Put a proposal to popular vote
- The weaker the president, the closer the cabinet will resemble the legislative majority

Semi-presidential democracies

- Two types:
  - **Premier-presidential system:** The government is responsible to the legislature **but not** the president
  - **President-parliamentary system:** The government is responsible to the legislature **AND** the president

Table 12.11 **Responsibility of Government in Each Type of Democracy**

	Parliamentary	Semi-presidential		Presidential
Responsible to:		**Premier-presidential**	**President-parliamentary**	
Legislature	YES	YES	YES	NO
President	NO	NO	YES	YES

Government formation

- **Government:** Prime minister and cabinet
- The **prime minister** is the **chief executive** and the **president** is the **head of state**
- The **executive branch** is the president and the government

Cohabitation

- In semi-presidential democracies, there is no guarantee that the president and PM will be from the same party
- **Cohabitation:** President and PM from different political blocs. It means the president's party does not have legislative majority
- **Cohabitation** $\neq$ **Divided government** `(Make sure you understand why!)`
- Cohabitation can lead to effective checks and balances, or bitter conflict between political actors

Making sense of all of it

- Parliamentary, presidential, and semi-presidential are **general categories**
- A lot of variation in rules, procedures, and norms beyond these
- At the core, we find different forms of **delegation**

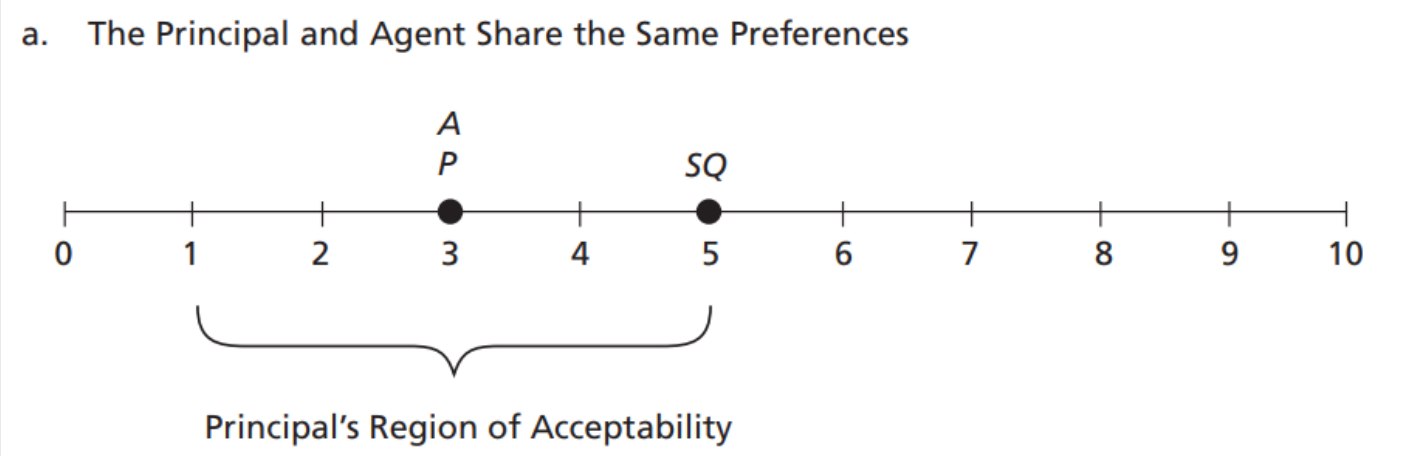
Principal-agent model

- **Delegation:** A **principal** relies on an **agent** to act on the principal's behalf
- Cabinet members are agents of the chief executive
- Chief executives are agents of the legislative majority
- Legislators are agents of their party
- Elected officials are agents of their constituency

Principal-agent game

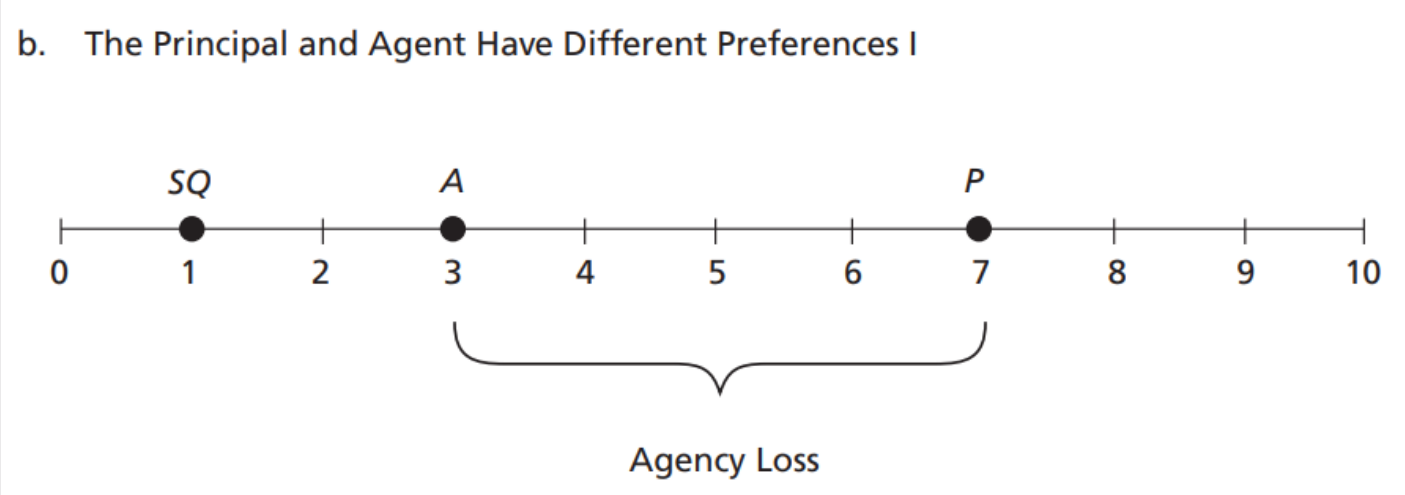
- Two actors: Principal and agent
- Single-peaked preferences, one dimensional space from 0-10
- Preferred output as ideal points P and A, respectively
- Status quo SQ
- Agent proposes a policy on the 0-10 space
    - If principal accepts, policy is implemented
    - If principal rejects, SQ remains
- Result depends on distribution of preferences

Same preferences



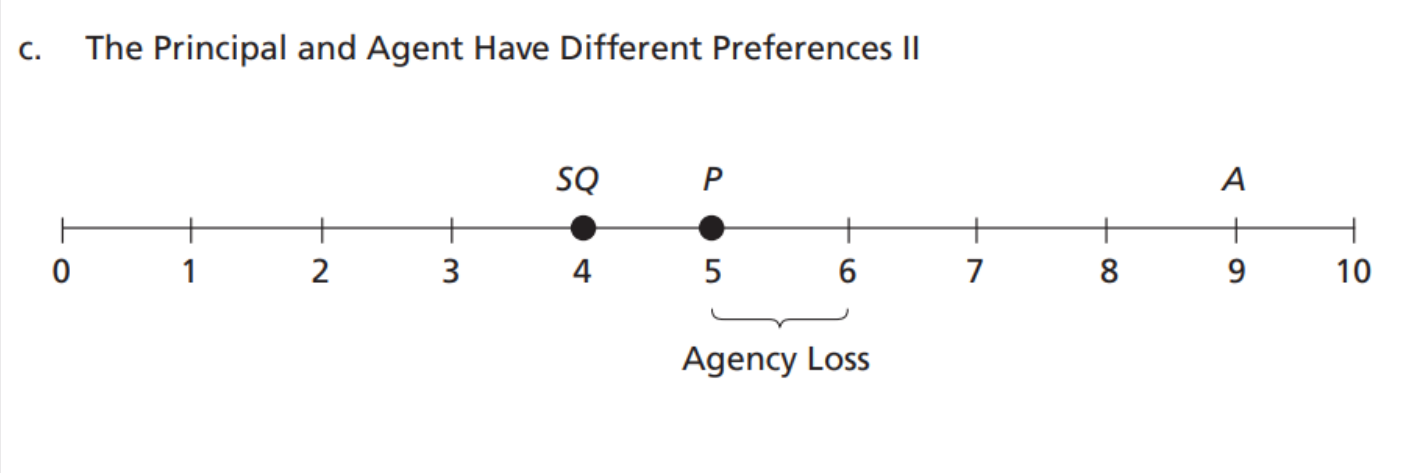
- If they both agree, they implement their desired policy
- This is the case with a single-party majority

Different preferences I



- Principal prefers $P > A > SQ$
- Will accept A although it entails **agency loss**
- Policy concessions can look like this

Different preferences II



- Principal prefers P over SQ
- They are willing to take agency loss $P + 1 = 6$ so that agent agrees to act on their behalf
- Sometimes chief executives need to make a coalition but have the upper hand in negotiations

Lessons from principal-agent model

- Delegation involves agency loss, but principals are better off from it
- Policy concessions are sometimes necessary to avoid problems with decision-making
- But delegation creates asymmetric information
- Problems:
  1. **Adverse selection:** Principal cannot observe all of agent's attributes. **Types** are unobserved `(e.g. your cabinet member may be incompetent)`
  2. **Moral hazard:** Agent can operate behind principal's back. **Actions** are unobserved `(e.g. cabinet member makes deals to sabotage a bill)`
- If you were able to perfectly monitor an agent, then you do not need to delegate!

Takeaways

- Different types of democracy solve decision making problems differently
- Rules surrounding legislative responsibility dictate how to form governments
- Office and policy concessions make democracy the world
- **Delegation** is at the core of government formation in democracies
- Which in turn implies a complex web of principal-agent relationships

Reminder:

No assignment due this week

Enjoy Thanksgivng break!

After Break:

Elections and Electoral Systems